Development of a self-rating scale of self-directed learning

In order to realise their full potential as learners, it is essential that students have good self-directed learning skills. It is also important that students develop their own roles in learning by continuously monitoring their own learning progress, identifying areas of deficit and making a conscious effort towards self-improvement. In this paper, Swapna Naskar Williamson reports on the development and testing of a self-rating scale of self-directed learning in higher education, and considers how it might be used in practice in order to enhance the requisite skills for becoming independent and lifelong learners.

key words

- self-direction
- lifelong learning
- self-rating scale
- self-directed learner

Background

The development of self-directed learning skills has become one of the primary aims of adult education in the last few decades. Research and scholarship in self-directed learning have increased internationally, and new programmes, practices and resources for facilitating self-directed learning have been introduced to help educators as well as learners.

Knowles (1975) explained that self-directed learners are proactive and take the initiative in learning rather than passively waiting to be taught as reactive learners. Their learning is more meaningful and purposeful, with greater motivation resulting in longer retention. They are more responsible

in their own lives, having benefited from the self-disciplining process of their learning. According to Hiemstra (1994) and Brookfield (1986), self-directed learning is a process in which learners are responsible for planning, implementing, and evaluating their own learning and are expected to work independently or with others, in order to achieve pre-set learning goals. Knowles (1980) observed that students entering educational programmes without having learned skills of self-directed inquiry experienced anxiety, frustration and often failure.

Various studies have reported that students initially experience anxiety and fear about self-directed learning and express their need for formal instruction in the concept of the self-directed-learning process at the beginning of their courses (Hewitt-Taylor 2001, Lunyk-Child *et al* 2001, Miflin *et al* 2000, Nolan and Nolan 1997, Prociuk 1990). According to Knowles (1983), this desire for instruction reflects the fact that adults may be unfamiliar with self-directed learning and may find it problematic. Williams (2004) states that students should enter their professional courses with the understanding of and ability to engage in continuous learning in order to ensure competence in professional practice. In their study of teachers' and students' perceptions of self-directed learning, Lunyk-Child *et al* (2001) found that students undergo a transformation that begins with negative feelings but ends with confidence and skills in self-direction and during this transformation it is the responsibility of teachers to provide student support. Kell and Van Deursen (2002) expressed their view that it is the responsibility of educators to ensure that students acquire self-directed learning skills, which can be transferred from education to their place of work.

Universities have a vital role in responding to the challenges of society, especially when there is ample evidence of resistance to self-direction in adult learning (Hiemstra 1991, Hiemstra and Brockett 1994). Both learners and educators must possess a clear concept of self-directed learning and select the appropriate teaching-learning strategies to facilitate and enhance learners' abilities in becoming self-directed in their learning process, including in their self-assessment (Norman 1999).

The literature review revealed that Guglielmino's (1977) SDLRS was used as a practical instrument for measuring self-directed learning readiness. However,

there is still a need for instruments to assess self-directed learning behaviour that are different from the simple measuring of perceptions and readiness for self-directed learning (Brockett and Hiemstra 1991). Having considered demographic changes in the universities' student population, the dearth of suitable instruments for assessing learners' levels of self-directedness in learning, and, more importantly, students' need for guidance in becoming self-directed learners as evidenced from the above review, the author attempted to develop an instrument to measure learners' levels of self-directedness in learning.

The self-rating scale of self-directed learning (SRSSDL)

Self-direction is the basis of all learning; be it formal or informal, the effectiveness of learning is relative to an individual's motivation. All individuals are capable of self-directed learning but the degree of development varies due to their individual differences. It is important that both educators and learners have a clear understanding of the concept and nature of self-directed learning skills for its further development. Educators, in this context, have the added responsibility of developing learners' full potential in effective self-directed learning through building and maintaining a harmonious team relationship.

The 60-item SRSSDL is an instrument developed for measuring the level of self-directedness in one's learning process. Knowledge of learners' levels of self-directedness will benefit both learners and educators. Firstly, students responding to the SRSSDL items will not only reveal their own levels of self-directedness in learning, but will also have the opportunity to develop an insight into self-directed learning and a better understanding of the concept, which is crucial for developing of self-directed, independent and lifelong learning. Secondly, teachers, having identified learners' levels of self-directedness and deficits in learning, will be better able to guide students from their positions of learning dependence to independence, considering each student's individual learning needs.

Methodology

A developmental and descriptive qualitative research approach was used to achieve the following study objectives:

- To develop a self-rating scale of self-directed learning (SRSSDL)

- To test the scale, and establish its reliability and construct validity

The study comprised two parts. Part 1 included use of the Delphi technique to develop and to determine content validity of the SRSSDL. Part 2 involved testing and establishing reliability and construct validity of the SRSSDL.

Part 1: The development of the SRSSDL

Extensive literature was reviewed, and in particular the works of Guglielmino (1977), Knowles (1975), Candy (1991), Hiemstra (1994) and Brookfield (1986), to prepare a list of attributes, skills and competences of self-directed learners. A list of 75 items, each reflecting the requisite behaviour of self-directed learners was developed. Consultation with professional colleagues also helped in the development of these items for the SRSSDL. Special attention was paid to using only short and simple sentences in order to keep the meaning clear and unambiguous.

Delphi Technique

The Delphi technique was used to develop the SRSSDL; this technique aims to obtain judgements from a 'blind' panel of experts giving individual feedback on a specific subject that is then judged by the entire panel. The process is repeated, building on information obtained in each round, until there is some consensus (Polit and Hungler 1999, Sharkey and Sharples 2001).

A panel of 15 experts, comprising six nurse educators, six doctors and three practice educationalists, was purposively sampled from higher education institutions and teaching hospitals. Inclusion criteria included the requirement that each member had a postgraduate qualification with a minimum of three years' teaching experience. Each member was informed of the purpose of the study and consented to participate in it.

The SRSSDL was sent electronically to panel members. Each member responded to the items individually and independently, and returned his or her response electronically to the researcher. Responses were obtained for each item using a five-point Likert scale, with a score of one for 'strongly disagree' and a score of five for 'strongly agree'. The scale included a 'remark' column for panel members to comment on or modify any item. For an item to be retained in the scale, at least 75 per cent agreement was needed from

the panel of experts. Items for which agreement was less than 75 per cent were retained for modification and placement in the subsequent round. Items with less than 25 per cent agreement were deleted.

Results of the Delphi technique

In the first Delphi round, the SRSSDL contained 75 items; 10 items were deleted as they were disapproved of by 20-25 per cent of experts; 15 items were suggested for modification. In the first round, 50 items were approved by 80-90 per cent of the experts and were retained. In the second round, 65 items inclusive of 15 modified items were re-submitted to the experts. 5 items were deleted and 60 items retained having 80-85 per cent agreement of the experts. Results of the Delphi rounds are presented in Table 1.

Table 1. Delphi rounds consensus to select items for the SRSSDL

Round	Total number of items	Number of items deleted	Number of items retained	Number of items for modification
1	75	10	50	15
2	65	5	60	0

Two or three rounds are deemed adequate when a Delphi technique is used to explore a complex issue and for obtaining consensus (Jenkins and Smith 1994). There was no need for a third round because all 60 items received 80 -85 per cent agreement by the panel of experts. Thus, content validity was established through the Delphi technique experts' judgement. Subsequently, the 60-item SRSSDL was finalised.

The SRSSDL

The structure of the SRSSDL (Appendix 1) included a brief profile of respondents and general instructions on how to use the scale. The SRSSDL comprised of 60 items categorised under five broad areas of self-directed learning:

- **Awareness**: Twelve items relating to learners' understanding of the factors contributing to becoming self-directed learners.
- **Learning strategies**: Twelve items explaining the various strategies

self-directed learners should adopt in order to become self-directed in their learning processes.

- **Learning activities**: Twelve items specifying the requisite learning activities learners should actively engage in order to become self-directed in their learning processes.
- **Evaluation**: Twelve items revealing learners' specific attributes in order to help monitor their learning activities.
- **Interpersonal skills**: Twelve items relating to learners' skills in inter-personal relationships, which are pre-requisite to their becoming self-directed learners.

Responses for each item are be rated by using a five-point scale: 5 = always; 4 = often; 3 = sometimes; 2 = seldom; 1 = never. An 'any other' space was also included for each broad area of the SRSSDL. This was to provide an opportunity to the users of the SRSSDL to include any other relevant items they deemed fit. Thus, the SRSSDL became an open-ended instrument. The categorisation of SRSSDL items into five broad areas allows for specific areas where students lack abilities in their self-directedness to be identified and support offered. Students with high scores, indicating a high level of self-directedness in their learning, should also be supported in order to help maintain and further develop their abilities in becoming independent life-long learners.

Scoring the SRSSDL

All the items of the SRSSDL were positively stated. For each item the 'always' response was rated as 5 and the 'never' response was rated as 1. Thus, the maximum and the minimum possible scores of the SRSSDL were 300 and 60 respectively. A score sheet was developed to interpret responses. The scoring range in Table 2 indicates the respondents' level of self-direction in learning based, on their individual scores and the corresponding interpretation.

Part 2: Testing and establishing the construct validity and reliability of the SRSSDL

A purposive convenience sampling technique was used to select the study subjects comprising 15 first- and 15 final-year undergraduate nursing stu-

Table 2. Scoring range

Scoring range	Level of self-directed learning	Interpretation
60-140	Low	Guidance is needed from the teacher. Any specific changes necessary for improvement must be identified and a possible re-structuring of the methods of learning identified.
141-220	Moderate	This is half way to becoming a self-directed learner. Areas for improvement must be identified and evaluated, and a strategy adopted with teacher guidance when necessary.
221-300	High	This indicates effective self-directed learning. The goal is to maintain progress by identifying strengths and methods for consolidation of the students' effective self-directed learning.

dents aged from 20 to 25 years who were willing to participate. The SRSSDL was given to the students and the purpose of the study was explained to them. The instructions for the use of the SRSSDL were read out and students' queries were clarified.

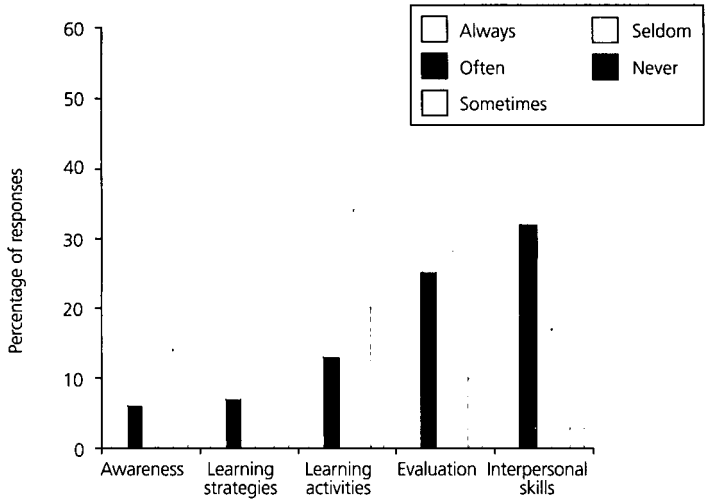
Data analysis

The data collected were arranged in a Microsoft Excel spreadsheet. The students' responses to the SRSSDL were summarised in frequencies and percentages. The responses of both the first and final year students were summed up in order to obtain the average scores to establish the construct validity.

Results

Figure 1 shows first year undergraduate nursing students' responses in the five broad areas of the SRSSDL. Most students responded with 'seldom' and 'sometimes' to all the broad areas, whereas only a small percentage responded to the options 'often' and 'always'. Data also showed 3-8 per cent of 'never' responses to the broad areas of the SRSSDL. Thus, the first year students' overall responses indicated a low level of self-direction in learning and established their need for support in developing self-directed learning

Figure [illegible] SRSSDL



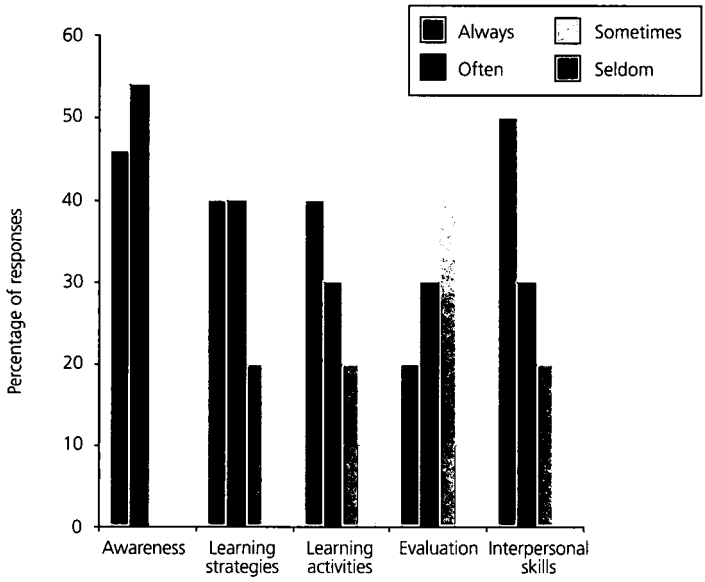
skills. The responses of the final year undergraduate nursing students to all the broad areas of the SRSSDL are presented in Figure 2.

Most students responded with 'always' and 'often' in all the broad areas of the SRSSDL. The responses 'sometimes' in the areas of Learning strategies, Learning activities, Evaluation and Interpersonal skills showed students' further need for development of self-directed learning skills. Furthermore, students' responses with 'seldom' in the areas of Learning activities and Evaluation indicated the need for student support in order to develop requisite skills in becoming self-directed learners. The final year students expressed interest in all the items of the SRSSDL and all reported that while responding to the SRSSDL items they developed a better understanding of self-directed learning skills. They also expressed their desire for further opportunities for self-directed learning.

Internal consistency and construct validity

To determine the internal consistency Cronbach's coefficient alpha was computed. In the alpha coefficient reliability test a result of more than 0.70 is

Figure 2. Final year students' responses to broad areas of the SRSSDL



generally considered to have an acceptable and satisfactory internal consistency (Nolan and Nolan 1997, Nunnally 1978, de Vaus 1991). Table 2 shows the obtained coefficient alpha of each broad area of the SRSSDL.

The computed coefficient alpha in all five areas indicates sufficient correlation. Consequently, all the items of self-directed learning were retained.

For establishing the construct validity a known-groups technique was used; it was observed that the first and final year students' average scores were 160 and 214 respectively. It is apparent that the final year students' scores were higher than the first year students. Although both the groups' average scores differed, they possessed the same characteristics specified in the SRSSDL.

Discussion

This study aimed to develop a valid and reliable scale to assess learners' self-directed learning skills. The content validity of the SRSSDL items were established following the review of related literature and through the appraisal

Table 2. SRS[illegible]
alpha [illegible]

Broad area of the SRSSDL	Cronbach's alpha coefficient
Awareness	0.79
Learning strategies	0.73
Learning activities	0.71
Evaluation	0.71
Inter-personal Skills	0.71

of the panel of experts participating in the Delphi technique. The responses of the first and final year students reveal that the final year students are more self-directed in learning than the first-year students, who have more limited skills in self-directed learning. This indicates that adult learners with more experience appear to be more self-directed in their learning processes. According to Sabbaghian (1980), individuals who have completed more years of formal education tended to demonstrate a higher self-directed learning preparedness. All the students participating in the study showed specific interest in the items of SRSSDL and found responding to the SRSSDL was useful in developing a clearer concept and better understanding of self-directed learning skills. Students require a formal introduction to the concept of self-directed learning and also need to be supported in its development (Hewitt-Taylor 2001, Iwasiw 1987, Lunyk-Child *et al* 2001, Miflin *et al* 2000, Nolan and Nolan 1997b, Prociuk 1990). Self-directed learning skills could be developed through careful planning and integration into the curriculum (Grow 1991). According to Candy (1991), self-directed learning, especially of discipline-based knowledge, calls on attitudes, skills and knowledge that can be intentionally developed through planned educational interventions.

The present study was limited to obtaining data only from the undergraduate nursing student population. The individual students' responses to the SRSSDL could be tested to find out the level of self-directed learning skills of the students who participated in the study for a better comparison. The

SRSSDL items were positively stated and no problems were identified in obtaining responses from the students. But in order to reduce responder bias and to prevent them from just scanning the items and giving a similar score to each item, some statements could be negatively worded. An item analysis of the scale could be conducted on a larger sample.

The SRSSDL was found to be a valid and reliable instrument in assessing learners' levels of self-direction in learning and can be used to facilitate teaching-learning processes in furtherance of their self-directed learning skills. However, further research is required on a larger sample for generalisation and also for its wider application on student populations of other disciplines. Research is needed that entails exploration of the predictive validity of the SRSSDL. Cross-sectional and longitudinal studies are necessary to find out the relationship between students' SRSSDL scores and academic performance scores. Research is also recommended to study the relationship between the SRSSDL scores, age and gender of students. Research on teachers' preferences/attitudes regarding the SRSSDL as an instrument for assessing students' self-directed learning skills is essential so as to discover how well the self-directed learning process is working for the students.

Conclusion

The SRSSDL developed in this study using the modified Delphi technique was found to be a valid and reliable instrument in identifying learners' levels of self-direction in learning. The accurate assessment of one's own strengths and deficiencies is the first step towards self-directed learning (Regehr *et al*, 1996). Students, while responding to the items of the SRSSDL, will develop a clearer concept and understanding of self-directed learning behaviour, identify the areas of their own strength and weaknesses and select appropriate strategies for furtherance of their self-directed learning skills. The teachers will also be able to carefully and sensitively develop 'smart' instructional materials and support students in making a conscious effort towards their self-improvement.

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Appendix [illegible] (SRSS)

Code no._____ Sex_____ Discipline_____ Date of testing _____

Age:	Tick
20-29	
30-39	
40-49	
50 -59	
>60	

This response sheet is to try to identify learner's levels of self–directedness in learning in higher education. Please read and encircle the most appropriate response for each statement indicating the level at which you rate yourself. Please note that your first reaction to the statement is the most accurate response; therefore, do not spend too long a time on one item. Your responses will be kept confidential, so please feel free to respond. The 'any other' space is provided for you to add any other issues about self-directedness in learning you think relevant. A 'scoring sheet' is included for you to assess the level of your self-directedness in learning.

Areas of Self-Directedness in learning

Response Key: 5 = Always 4 = Often 3 = Sometimes 2 =Seldom; 1 = Never

1	Awareness	Score				
1.1	I identify my own learning needs	5	4	3	2	1
1.2	I am able to select the best method for my own learning	5	4	3	2	1
1.3	I consider teachers as facilitators of learning rather than providing information only	5	4	3	2	1
1.4	I keep up to date on different learning resources available	5	4	3	2	1
1.5	I am responsible for my own learning	5	4	3	2	1
1.6	I am responsible for identifying my areas of deficit	5	4	3	2	1
1.7	I am able to maintain self-motivation	5	4	3	2	1
1.8	I am able to plan and set my learning goals	5	4	3	2	1
1.9	I have a break during long periods of work	5	4	3	2	1

1.10	I need to keep my learning routine separate from my other commitments	5	4	3	2	1
1.11	I relate my experience with new information	5	4	3	2	1
1.12	I feel that I am learning despite not being instructed by a lecturer	5	4	3	2	1
1.13	Any other	5	4	3	2	1
2	**Learning Strategies**	**Score**				
2.1	I participate in group discussions	5	4	3	2	1
2.2	I find peer coaching effective	5	4	3	2	1
2.3	I find 'role play' is a useful method for complex learning	5	4	3	2	1
2.4	I find inter-active teaching-learning sessions more effective than just listening to lectures	5	4	3	2	1
2.5	I find simulation in teaching-learning useful	5	4	3	2	1
2.6	I find learning from case studies useful	5	4	3	2	1
2.7	My inner drive directs me towards further development and improvement in my learning	5	4	3	2	1
2.8	I regard problems as challenges	5	4	3	2	1
2.9	I arrange my self-learning routine in such a way that it helps develop a permanent learning culture in my life	5	4	3	2	1
2.10	I find concept mapping is an effective method of earning	5	4	3	2	1
2.11	I find modern educational interactive technology enhances my learning process	5	4	3	2	1
2.12	I am able to decide my own learning strategy	5	4	3	2	1
2.13	Any other	5	4	3	2	1
3	**Learning activities**	**Score**				
3.1	I rehearse and revise new lessons	5	4	3	2	1
3.2	I identify the important points when reading a chapter or an article	5	4	3	2	1
3.3	I use concept mapping/outlining as a useful method of comprehending a wide range of information	5	4	3	2	1
3.4	I am able to use information technology effectively.	5	4	3	2	1
3.5	My concentration intensifies and I become more attentive when I read a complex study content	5	4	3	2	1
3.6	I keep annotated notes or a summary of all my ideas, reflections and new learning	5	4	3	2	1

3.7	I enjoy exploring information beyond the prescribed course objectives	5	4	3	2	1
3.8	I am able to relate knowledge with practice	5	4	3	2	1
3.9	I raise relevant question(s) in teaching-learning sessions	5	4	3	2	1
3.10	I am able to analyse and critically reflect on new ideas, information or any learning experiences	5	4	3	2	1
3.11	I keep an open mind to others' point of view	5	4	3	2	1
3.12	I prefer to take any break in between any learning task	5	4	3	2	1
3.13	Any other	5	4	3	2	1
4	**Evaluation**	**Score**				
4.1	I self-assess before I get feed back from instructors	5	4	3	2	1
4.2	I identify the areas for further development in whatever I have accomplished	5	4	3	2	1
4.3	I am able to monitor my learning progress	5	4	3	2	1
4.4	I am able to identify my areas of strength and weakness	5	4	3	2	1
4.5	I appreciate when my work can be peer reviewed	5	4	3	2	1
4.6	I find both success and failure inspire me to further learning	5	4	3	2	1
4.7	I value criticism as the basis of bringing improvement to my learning	5	4	3	2	1
4.8	I monitor whether I have accomplished my learning goals	5	4	3	2	1
4.9	I check my portfolio to review my progress	5	4	3	2	1
4.10	I review and reflect on my learning activities	5	4	3	2	1
4.11	I find new learning challenging	5	4	3	2	1
4.12	I am inspired by others' success	5	4	3	2	1
4.13	Any other	5	4	3	2	1
5	**Interpersonal skills**	**Score**				
5.1	I intend to learn more about other cultures and languages I am frequently exposed to	5	4	3	2	1
5.2	I am able to identify my role within a group	5	4	3	2	1
5.3	My interaction with others helps me to develop the insight to plan for further learning	5	4	3	2	1
5.4	I make use of any opportunities I come across	5	4	3	2	1

5.5	I need to share information with others	5	4	3	2	1
5.6	I maintain good inter-personal relationships with others	5	4	3	2	1
5.7	I find easy to work in collaboration with others	5	4	3	2	1
5.8	I am successful in communicating verbally	5	4	3	2	1
5.9	I identify the need for inter-disciplinary links for maintaining social harmony	5	4	3	2	1
5.10	I am able to express my ideas effectively in writing	5	4	3	2	1
5.11	I am able to express my views freely	5	4	3	2	1
5.12	I find it challenging to pursue learning in a culturally diverse milieu	5	4	3	2	1
5.13	Any other	5	4	3	2	1

Scoring Sheet: Self-Rating Scale for Self- Directedness in Learning (SRSSDL)

Once you have responded to all the items of the SRSSDL, transfer the scores to the correct boxes below and add up your scores as in the following example:

Example:

Score	5	4	3	2	1	
Items 1.1-1.12	3	4	3	5	0	
Total	15	16	9	10	0	Total score = 50

Score	5	4	3	2	1	
Items 1.1-1.12						
Total						Total score =

Score	5	4	3	2	1	
Items 2.1-2.12						
Total						Total score =

Score	5	4	3	2	1	
Items 3.1-3.12						
Total						Total score =

Score	5	4	3	2	1	
Items 4.1-4.12						
Total						Total score =

Score	5	4	3	2	1	
Items 5.1-5.12						
Total						Total score =

Add all the total scores

☐ + ☐ + ☐ + ☐ + ☐ = ☐

Check the grand total score with the following scoring range in order to identify your level of self-directedness in learning.

Scoring range	Level of self-directedness in learning	Interpretation
60-140	**Low**	Guidance is definitely needed from the teacher. Any specific changes necessary for improvement must be identified and a possible complete re-structuring of the methods of learning
141-220	**Moderate**	This is half way to becoming a self-directed learner. Areas for improvement must be identified, evaluated and a strategy adopted with teacher guidance when necessary
221-300	**High**	This indicates effective self-directed learning. The goal now is to maintain progress by identifying strengths and methods for consolidation of the students' effective self-directed learning

No matter what your total score, it is essential that you pay particular attention to any individual items of the SRSSDL in which you have scored below 3, as these are the areas in which you definitely need to improve.

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